Djokovic's Season Ends With a Surprise Defeat in Paris

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Novak Djokovic's season is over, and it ended with a surprise. The 39-year-old tennis star lost 2-6, 6-3, 6-3 to Rinky Hijikata, a **qualifier** from Australia **ranked** 83rd in the world, in the second round of the Paris Masters on Wednesday. The defeat knocked Djokovic out of the race for the ATP Finals in Turin. He likely needed to reach the **semi-finals** in Paris to qualify, and the draw had seemed to open up for him after two of his rivals lost earlier in the day. Djokovic started well, but Hijikata raised his level late in the second set and through the deciding set, while Djokovic, who looked tired and was struggling physically, made a string of errors. After the match, Djokovic said his plan for the next few weeks is "just rest." "I'm looking forward to it," he added. He praised his opponent, too: "He played really amazing tennis and it was my fault to let the control of the match go." Djokovic, who owns a men's record 24 **Grand Slam** singles titles, has now failed to qualify for the **season-ending** event for only the second time in 20 seasons when fit. He reached the Australian Open final and the Wimbledon **semi-finals** this year, yet he has not reached a quarter-final at any of this year's **Masters 1000** events. His last **Grand Slam** title came at the US Open in 2023. Qualifying for Turin would have given him a shot at a record-extending eighth title at the **season-ending** championships. Instead, only Americans Taylor Fritz and Tommy Paul remain in the hunt for the final two places, currently held by Frances Tiafoe and Rafael Jodar. Tiafoe lost to France's Quentin Halys, and Alex de Minaur lost to Tomas Martin Etcheverry of Argentina. Zverev and Medvedev, who have both already qualified, were also beaten.

Word Treasure

qualifier -- A qualifier is a player who must win extra matches to enter a tournament.

semi-finals -- The semi-finals are the round before the final.

Grand Slam -- A Grand Slam is one of the four biggest tennis tournaments.

Masters 1000 -- Masters 1000 events are big tennis tournaments just below the Grand Slams.

ranked -- Ranked means placed in order by how good a player is.

season-ending -- Season-ending means happening at the end of the season.

Background you need

Tennis is played in tournaments, where players must win match after match to reach the final.

The ATP Finals is a season-ending tournament for the best players of the year.

A Grand Slam is one of the four biggest tennis tournaments in the world.

A qualifier is a lower-ranked player who must win extra matches just to enter the main tournament.

Break it down

LEAD: Djokovic's season ends with a surprise defeat in Paris
KEY EVENT: Second-round loss to qualifier Rinky Hijikata
+- WHO: Djokovic, Hijikata, Fritz and Paul
+- WHERE: The Paris Masters
+- WHEN: Wednesday
EVIDENCE: 24 Grand Slam titles, but no Masters 1000 quarter-final this year
OPEN QUESTION: Can Fritz or Paul grab the last spots in Turin?

Why it matters

Even the greatest players can lose to an underdog, and that is what makes sports exciting to watch.

Test what you remember

1. Who beat Novak Djokovic in Paris?

(A) Alexander Zverev of Germany
(B) Rinky Hijikata of Australia
(C) Daniil Medvedev
(D) Taylor Fritz of the United States

2. What was the score?

(A) 2-6, 6-3, 6-3
(B) 6-3, 6-3, 6-3
(C) 6-2, 6-3, 6-3
(D) 2-6, 3-6, 3-6

3. What did Djokovic say his plan is for the next few weeks?

(A) Just rest
(B) Retire from tennis
(C) Play another tournament
(D) Train harder

4. How many Grand Slam singles titles has Djokovic won?

(A) 24
(B) 22
(C) 20
(D) 18

5. How many times has Djokovic failed to qualify for the season-ending event when fit in 20 seasons?

(A) Ten times
(B) Every year
(C) Only twice
(D) Five times

6. Who still has a chance to take the last two spots in Turin?

(A) Tiafoe and Jodar
(B) Zverev and Medvedev
(C) Taylor Fritz and Tommy Paul
(D) Halys and Etcheverry

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Novak Djokovic: says he will just rest and that it was his fault he let control of the match go

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):